sity, Kota (2013-2015), and AKTU (2015-21), where he did two terms. In fact, Pathak was considered so indispensable that in the past two years he was also given additional charge of two universities, Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti Bhasha University, Lucknow (December 2020 to April 2021), and Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar University, Agra (January-September 2022).

Despite repeated requests, the offices of CM Yogi Adityanath as well as that of governor Anandiben Patel refused to respond on the issue. Taking action against a sitting V-C is next to impossible without the sanction of either of the two offices, and top sources in the administration say there is some strain between the two over the issue.

Pathak seems to have connections cutting across party lines. A Kanpur native, he became V-C at the age of 40. A source close to him says a Congress leader helped him get his first post in 2009. But after 2014, it's his connections with the BJP that have helped him. In Lucknow, everyone knows about his strong ties with a central minister and another Rajya Sabha member of the ruling party. Even in the Yogi government, a cabinet minister is said to be close to him. Now his political connections are also under the scanner. The source close to Pathak also hinted that the V-C, who has had dealings with many top leaders and bureaucrats over the years, is privy to their secrets, which is perhaps why he has still not been arrested. "Many secrets will tumble out if Pathak is arrested," he says ominously. And so he roams free. ■





**FATAL CLASH** A Gutti Koya tribal hamlet inside a Telangana forest; (inset) murdered FRO Srinivasa Rao

lost forever. The Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, grants *podu* cultivators only a 'right for cultivation' certificate. It does not grant ownership, which is vested with the forest department. This has led to friction between the two sides over the years.

Forest officials suspect that some of the tribals, especially the Gutti Koya, are being egged on by the Maoists. Since 2005, there has been an influx of Gutti Koya from Chhattisgarh, who migrated here after years of persecution at the hands of the Salwa Judum (the state-sponsored militia) and left-wing extremists. This also led to another dimension in the deepening state versus tribal conflict—local communities want the Gutti Koya squatters evicted. After the FRO's murder, furious residents of the Bendalapadu gram panchayat, led by sarpanch P. Venkateswara Rao, have demanded that the state government clear the Yerrabodu habitation and send the Gutti Koya community there back to Chhattisgarh. "They came from the Sukma region and should be sent back at any cost as they do not belong here," says Rao.

Encroachments by migrants and the humanitarian question is a growing challenge for the ruling Telangana Rashtra Samithi. KCR had launched the 'Telangana ku Haritha Haram (A green garland for Telangana)' campaign in 2015, soon after he came to power for the first time. Consistent efforts since then have increased the state's green cover by 7.7 per cent and the forest cover by 6.9 per cent in seven years. Numerous initiatives, many with active people's participation, were launched to achieve afforestation targets and raise green consciousness, including planting of some 200 million seedlings and rejuvenation of 800 million plants in the forests. But the absence of a clear policy on encroachments and resettlement of tribals—if necessary by amending the Recognition of Forest Rights Act—could see all the efforts on the afforestation front come to naught. ■